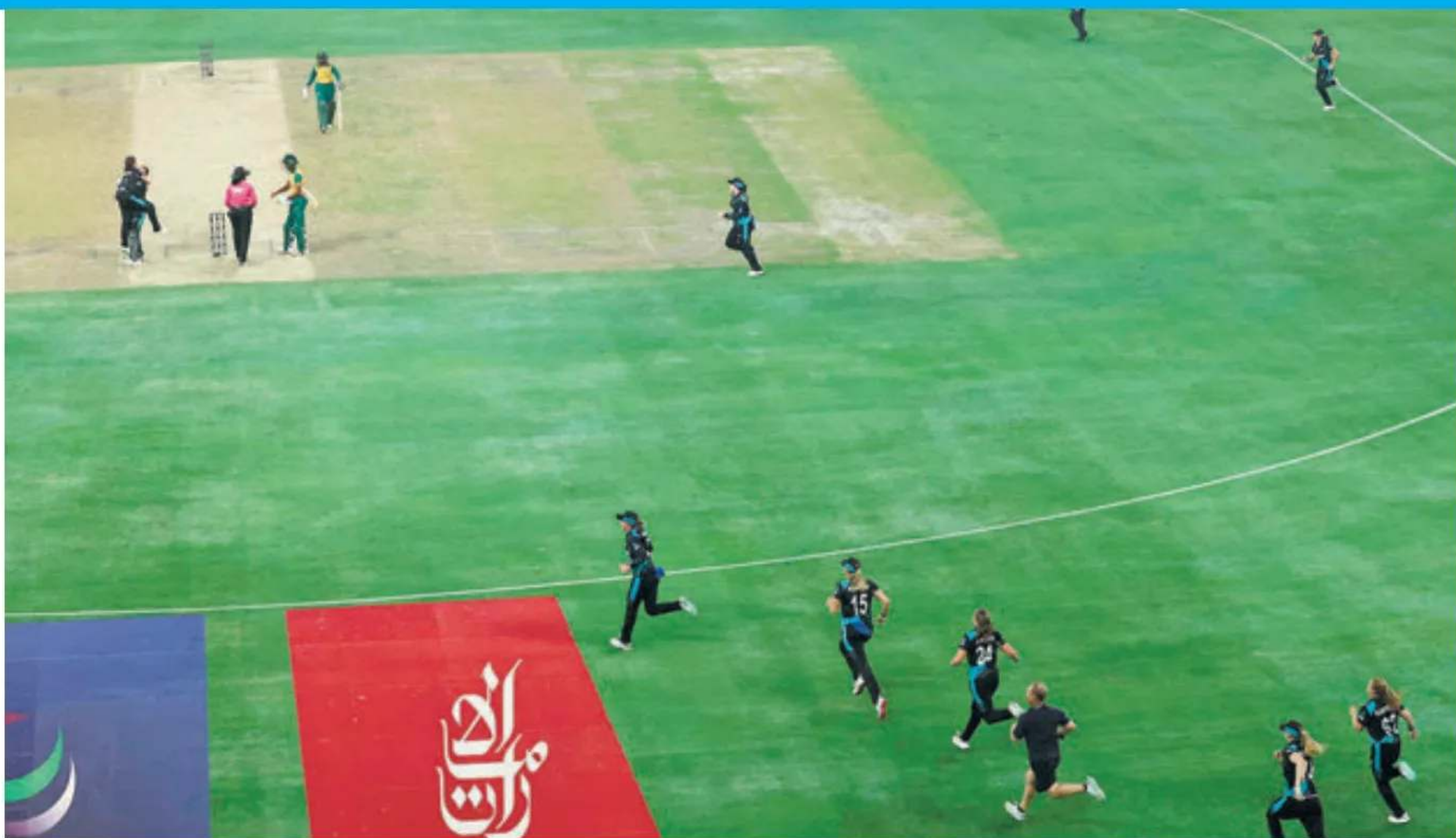




Passing the baton: The younger players in the team have also allowed the old guard to go through the rigours of the tournament on a lighter note. AFP

was filled with heartbreak. New Zealand was knocked out in the group stages in all editions across two formats until the 2024 edition. The side's run to the semifinal involved plenty of belief in different players who stepped up in various games.

Rosemary Mair, who returned to the side after a back injury layoff, starred with the ball, particularly against India in the campaign opener and South Africa in the final. Bates and Georgia Plimmer put in a spirited shift at the top of the order.

Amelia was talismanic for the side as expected, positioning herself nicely to be a key contender for the captain's armband after Devine. In the final, she battled cramps and struck with both ball and bat to help the White Ferns make history. So many of these individual player journeys intersect with Devine and Bates and the doors they opened for the generations after them.

"I was inspired to be a White Fern watching that 2010 World Cup which Sophie was at (New Zealand agonisingly lost that final to Australia by just three runs), and from that

moment, I was at the nets with my dad, pretending I was batting with Sophie and Suzie. Being in the team so young and playing with my role models, who have been so good to me and are two of New Zealand's greatest ever cricketers...is incredible," Amelia said after the triumph, with Devine by her side.

"I don't necessarily believe you deserve things in sport, but if any two people do, it's Sophie and Suzie. And I just think back to myself as a kid who was batting with Sophie and Suzie in the nets. When I was in primary school, in creative writing, I wrote about winning a World Cup with Sophie and Suzie. So, to be here now, having done that, I think that's probably why I'm so emotional. It's so special when I think back to my younger self and then about being here now, doing this with two of New Zealand's best ever."

Devine has been at the helm of the White Ferns for over 60 T20I matches and 44 ODIs. She will lead New Zealand in the three-match ODI series against India, part of the Women's Championship, just a few days after winning the final.

The 35-year-old is well aware that her job is to prepare New Zealand for a life after the Bates-Devine-Tahuhu trifecta, and the World Cup has been a perfect way to herald a new chapter while giving the previous one a satisfying end. Performances from Plimmer, Eden Carson, Fran Jonas, and others — with almost every game seeing a new player step up to carry the side through — will be the Kiwis' biggest takeaway.

The younger players in the team have also allowed the old guard to go through the rigours of the tournament on a lighter note.

"Half the time I can't understand what they're saying, so I need a translator to be able to work out what they're saying to me," Devine quipped early on in the tournament.

"The energy that they bring, it's sort of quite refreshing for the likes of myself, Suzie, and Lea, who have been at a number of these tournaments. To see their eyes light up at different opportunities and to see just being at a World Cup and how special it is, and what an honour it is, has been really cool for us. It doesn't matter if it's your first or your